



“BIMSTEC POISED TO PLAY A VERY IMPORTANT ROLE”

Indra Mani Pandey, Secretary General of the seven-member bloc, on the upcoming summit, boosting trade, and more

BY NAVNEET DUBEY

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THE BAY OF BENGAL

Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC)—a seven-member bloc of India, Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Myanmar, Thailand, and Sri Lanka—is quickly becoming the centrepiece of India’s trade policy in its neighbourhood. Leading this effort is Indra Mani Pandey, a senior diplomat and the organisation’s fourth Secretary General. In an interview, Pandey, 58, discusses BIMSTEC’s role in promoting regional co-operation, and the immense potential of the Bay of Bengal’s blue economy. Edited excerpts:



With the Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led government looking to

improve economic engagement in the region, what are the top priorities for BIMSTEC? What specific achievements are you hoping to see BIMSTEC accomplish?

The role of the secretariat is to assist the member states in translating their decisions into concrete initiatives for co-operation. My task is to ensure that the secretariat functions effectively and is able to support the member states.

Though there is no doubt that BIMSTEC could have achieved more, it is poised to play an important role in the future in enhancing regional co-operation in South Asia and South-east Asia.

The BIMSTEC Charter, which was adopted

during the fifth summit held in Colombo in March 2022, provides a road map for co-operation. At the sixth summit that is to be held later this year in Bangkok, the BIMSTEC leaders are expected to adopt the Bangkok Vision 2030 aimed at achieving a prosperous, resilient, and open BIMSTEC. This is the first time that such a document will be adopted by the bloc. Further, there is an eminent persons group (EPG) mandated to make recommendations to reform, revitalise and repurpose BIMSTEC. The EPG is expected to submit its report to the leaders at the next summit. BIMSTEC is thus set to undergo transformative changes.



The Bay of Bengal is a crucial region for trade and connectivity. How can BIMSTEC further strengthen maritime co-operation among its seven member states, including on issues like security and disaster management?

The BIMSTEC member states have finalised the text of an Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation, which is expected to be signed in Bangkok. It will help strengthen co-operation, leading to more regional economic growth and commercial exchange.

India has been designated as the lead member state to pursue co-operation in the security sector. It has a range of mechanisms to promote regional co-operation in different aspects of security. These include, for example, a Joint Working Group on Counter Terrorism and Transnational Crime to work at both policy and operational levels. It has several sub-groups working in specific areas, such as intelligence sharing; prevention of illicit trafficking in narcotic drugs, psychotropic substances and precursor chemicals; anti-money laundering and combating financing of terrorism; countering radicalisation and terrorism etc.

Additionally, there